The Purpose of the Power

This is a position paper from the Andover Democratic Town Committee, and we invite our fellow committees to amend it and adopt it.

On November 3, voters gave Democrats control of both the House and the Senate. Advice about what to do with that power is arriving from every direction. We would like to offer ours.

Accept the power, and use it with discipline. The test for every hearing, subpoena, and bill should not be how many wins it produces, or how easily they come, but how much it matters. These majorities are real but limited: the President still holds the veto, neither chamber has the two-thirds needed to override one, and the Senate majority is short of the 60 votes needed to end a filibuster. Choosing well matters all the more.

Some urge Democrats to keep their heads down: pass cost-of-living bills, skip the investigations, avoid any hint of overreach. They are right about the first part. Families are hurting, and lowering the cost of health care, groceries, and energy is part of the mandate. But oversight does not distract from that work. Corruption raises costs, and so does a war. Voters understand this: ninety percent of Election Day voters polled called corruption a crucial or major problem.

Others urge Democrats to do everything at once: impeach official after official, abolish agencies, rewrite the Senate's rules, and settle every score by spring. We share the anger. But anger is not a plan. Impeachment is a constitutional tool and should remain available for serious, proven offenses, yet conviction takes 67 senators, and a majority that tries everything finishes little. After Watergate, the change that lasted came from laws, not from fury: the Impoundment Control Act, independent inspectors general, and ethics rules that outlived the scandal.

So where should a disciplined Congress begin?

Start with the people who were harmed. Sixty deaths in ICE detention have been reported so far in this term, and the 37 in fiscal year 2026 were the most in the agency's history. In Minneapolis in January, agents of ICE and the Border Patrol shot and killed two U.S. citizens, Renee Good and Alex Pretti. The 2025 budget law gave ICE roughly $75 billion in new money. Congress should follow the money at ICE and CBP, require an independent investigation of every death and shooting, and attach conditions to every dollar, beginning with body cameras and visible identification for agents.

Ask what DOGE actually did. It closed in July, but not before an office led by one of the wealthiest men in the world claimed about $110 billion in savings from canceled contracts, grants, and leases. Congress's own auditors found that it gave too little information to verify 96 percent of the grant savings it reported.

Look at what was destroyed. USAID has been dismantled, and researchers project more than 14 million additional deaths by 2030 if the cuts stand, nearly a third of them children under five. The Department of Education is being parceled out to other agencies even though Congress kept funding it. Congress should document the damage and rebuild what it can in law.

Pursue corruption before incompetence, and begin with the President's chief aides and family, where the record is clearest. A firm backed by the national security adviser of the United Arab Emirates reportedly paid $500 million for 49 percent of the family's cryptocurrency company, in a deal signed four days before the inauguration. Questions like that deserve sworn testimony and documents, not

speculation. Congress should hold itself to the same standard and ban its own members from trading stocks.

Release the Epstein files, all of them, as the law already requires, and investigate how the Justice Department handled them. Then leave the question of who committed crimes to prosecutors, not to televised hearings.

Examine the wars. The conflict with Iran began without a vote of Congress. It had killed 18 American service members by mid-September and cost $38 billion by August. In the Caribbean and the Pacific, military strikes on boats have killed more than 200 people, likewise unauthorized. Since the raid that captured Venezuela's president in January, the President says the United States has sold more than $13 billion of Venezuelan oil, and no full public accounting of that money exists. Lawmakers should demand one, reclaim their war powers, and investigate anyone positioned to profit, including officials and relatives with stakes in defense businesses.

Repair the institutions. For two years, congressional oversight largely failed. The power of the purse has been treated as optional: Congress's own auditors have found the Administration's "pocket rescissions" unlawful, and the Supreme Court struck down tariffs imposed under emergency powers. The Administration has sent National Guard troops into states over their governors' objections, and courts have repeatedly ruled against its pressure campaigns on law firms and universities. Its leverage over private businesses deserves the same scrutiny. Hearings are not enough. Congress should write the limits into law: strengthen the Impoundment Control Act, protect inspectors general from removal, enforce the Constitution's emoluments clauses, and restore its own authority over war.

Welcome Republicans who join this work, but judge them by their votes, not by their expressions of concern. The law requiring release of the Epstein files exists because members of both parties forced it to the floor by petition. That kind of resolve has earned trust. Concern without a vote has not.

And let us keep our eyes on the ball. We want Democrats to keep winning. But winning is not the purpose. The purpose is to restore a government of the people, by the people, and for the people, and not one run for the President's wealthy cronies. Every hearing and every bill should be measured against that standard.